

Comets and meteors

Comets are enormous balls of snow and dust, like gigantic dirty snowballs. They live together in a huge cloud at the edge of our Solar System. Occasionally, a comet is knocked out of the cloud and starts a journey toward the Sun. You may see one in the night sky as it passes by Earth—it will look like a fuzzy star.

A comet's tail can be millions of miles in length.

The main body of the comet, the nucleus, is in the middle of this big head of gas and dust, called the coma.

Hot and dusty

Some comets travel into the main part of the Solar System. As a comet approaches the Sun, the Sun's heat starts to turn the comet's dirty snow into gas and dust. A tail grows as the comet loses material. The tail gets smaller and smaller as the comet moves away from the Sun.

